

Ministering to Yourself Until Faith Overtakes the Stronghold

One thing I found private worship to be, of course, is what Ephesians 5 says: you are ministering to yourselves.

"Speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs..."

He pretty much covered the whole spectrum of worship, including private worship. At the same time that you are glorifying God and worshipping Him, the real person you are ministering to is you. He is not capable of change. You are.

It is you that you are ministering to, and it is interesting what part of you is being ministered to.

As you go on in the same chapter, Paul says Jesus is the head, the covering, of the church, and the Savior of the body. As we have said so many times when we broke this down, head means covering and provider. Savior of the body means He saved you out of something to save you into something: out of sin and into righteousness, out of poverty and into His blessing, and on and on.

When Paul finished that tremendous teaching on husband and wife and Christ and the church, he said men ought to cherish and honor their wives even as Christ cherishes the church. Then he said it is a great mystery, but he was really speaking concerning Christ and the church.

If that is the case, then when you minister to yourself in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, you are the one on the move. Even though He is receiving the worship, you are the one changing. You are going from where you are to a place in Him that was provided two thousand years ago, where He not only cherishes you but nourishes you.

I would call that needs met, wouldn't you?

Why hang around in an emotional onslaught of defeat when you can go from here to there?

I thought when He taught me private worship it was so I could worship Him and teach on it, but He tricked me. God is a crafty God. I did not know it was the fellowship limb. I did not know it was that part I needed so I could go on and get to know my Father. It turned out to be a presence gift.

Did you have a good time when the man jumped out of the wheelchair and pushed it out Sunday morning, making loud comments on the way out? "I don't remember when I felt this good."

He was loading his own wheelchair in the car.

Why stay where you are when He has given you every key you need to make the journey?

"Brother, I did not earn my standing."

You certainly did not. And He has a standing in Himself as the covering and provider where He nourishes and cherishes you.

He brought it to a level you could understand. Today marriages are not in very good shape. Wouldn't you think with all the Word in Tulsa that we would have a higher rate of marriages making it?

When He used the relationship between a man and a woman to describe how a man should leave his father and mother, cleave to his wife, and the two should become one flesh, He was trying to get over to you the relationship Christ has with the church.

Bone of my bone, flesh of my flesh.

No more than you would let your wife starve to death, if things were right, you would cover and provide. You are the first line of defense. He said she is the weaker vessel, not that she is weaker in God, because the inside of the clay pot holds the same thing. Our outside is more rugged. Men were made more for the front line. Hers was the second line of defense.

That does not mean she cannot make her goods and sell them at the gates like the Proverbs woman. But the man's covering covers all that too. She does not have to lay down and quit. When it is right, all of it is covered.

A man who is a man would not dream of lying on his back while his wife went hungry. He would never dream of letting need take her over while there was enough life in his body to do something about it.

What makes you think Christ used that example and then did not leave you a way to get there?

Worship has everything to do with your emotions.

Paul said, "The weapons of our warfare are not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strongholds." We are talking about weaponry and an arsenal that is mighty, but mighty through God. These are weapons that belong to God. We are talking about weapons of mass destruction in God's arsenal.

Who erects the strongholds? The devil.

Who pulls them down? Thank you very much.

A stronghold would be like the forts that were put up in Indian Territory to protect settlements. When there were enough settlements, they would get the towns into the fort and make their stand there. That is what the devil likes to do.

The weapons of our warfare are mighty through God to the pulling down of his strongholds. Paul tells you what they are:

"Casting down imaginations,
and every high thing that exalteth itself
against the knowledge of God..."

An imagination is a system of thought empowered by emotion.

They say the strongest attribute of the soul is the will. I have seen emotion overturn the will a whole lot more than I have seen will overturn emotion. Usually will can last if your life is at stake, such as when you are thrown in prison, and even then it does not make it every time. A person has to have an extraordinarily strong will to survive in those emotional crises.

Usually the emotion wins. The hands go up: "I give up."

Emotion has a way of operating against you twenty-four hours a day sometimes. It wears you and wears you and wears you. The will is something you have to summon and use to make yourself stand. Sometimes you would not even know it was there unless you were classifying it: "I have a strong will."

But emotions? You know they are present. Usually everybody else does too.

So what kind of weapon could God possibly have for me that would pull down systems of thought empowered by emotions?

He has a positional truth for you. He says, "Husbands, treat your wives like I treat the church. I nourish it and cherish it."

If He said He does that, then He is doing that. His nourishing and cherishing are always present. But it is up to me to accept it and walk in it.

What did He say in Ephesians 5?

"Be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess;
but be filled with the Spirit."

What part of an alcoholic does alcohol affect? His emotions. His perception is altered. He either sees things better than they are or worse than they are, but his perception does not stay the same. Alcohol affects his emotions.

When Paul said, "Be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess, but be filled with the Spirit," he was saying, "Let Me show you how to affect your emotions with the right thing."

How?

"Speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs..."

Ministering to yourself. Who are you ministering to? Yourself.

Why? Because He has already provided the position. You are the one who needs to go there.

If every decision process in me is standing outside the nourishing and cherishing circle, and I have tried everything, taken everybody's counsel, heard everybody's teaching, and I know it is all mine, then yes, it is all mine. It is all mine by His grace. But how do I get from here to there?

If there is a truth and you are having trouble believing it, what makes you think He would not provide something for you to do to go from where you cannot believe it to where you can?

Do you think you have some half-time Father up there? Do you think He left something out? I do not think so.

Therefore the path to the miracle is as final, accessible, unchanging, and on purpose as the miracle itself.

"Please, if I cannot step over into nourishing and cherishing because of all these wonderful things placed in my mind, can You at least tell me how to take the first step?"

It just so happens that He can.

Be not drunk on emotion-altering wine, but be filled with the Spirit. How? Ministering to yourself. To yourself. To yourself.

Who has the problem? If there is nothing wrong with His operation, then where can we cast the shadow? There is nothing wrong with what He did for me. There is nothing wrong with redemption. There is nothing wrong with my liberty. There is nothing wrong with what He said.

So the problem is not on that end.

Ministering to who? Myself.

To be filled with the Spirit? I am already filled by the river, but this is not that kind. We are talking about the presence already in you taking the rest of you over. We are talking about Him taking the new nature that superseded, overpowered, displaced, and replaced the law of sin and death with the law of the Spirit of life, and magnifying it until your soul runs out of defeat and into victory.

I thought I would explain myself a little.

Where is my faith manifested?

My faith is manifested in believing what He said enough to stay in there and keep worshiping Him. Keep on. Stay in there until the imagination has been cast down, until the system of thoughts empowered by emotion is displaced, and the emotion is replaced by peace-resonating waves of joy and peace saying, "The Word of God is more true than that stronghold that thought it had finished me off."

Where is the fight fought?

Not in staring into the circle and wondering how to get there. The fight is fought by raising your hands and ministering to yourself every day until you step into the circle and begin to receive that place in Him.

The Holy Ghost will shed His love abroad in you. He will take that new nature and resonate it, magnify it so strongly through the rest of you that, just as alcohol impairs a man's senses, the Holy Ghost affects your senses in the opposite direction.

A drunk man may walk up to the governor of California, someone much stronger than he is, and say, "I am going to whip you." His senses are impaired. He is not evaluating things in the light they exist in. His emotions are seasoned in alcohol, and he is going to end up on the floor.

Now take that to the opposite extreme. I am ministering to myself with truths and worshipping God. He brings my new nature forward. I have victory until I step into the circle, and the opposite has taken place. I am so nourished, built up, and fortified in my emotions that they turn into peace and joy, declaring that I have it when the devil says I do not.

Ephesians 5 begins this part of the teaching with ministering to yourself. You do not have to be drunk on wine. You can build yourself up, ministering to yourself in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs. Then Paul goes on to that position a man has in Christ, where Christ nourishes and cherishes. He uses the family unit, then says, "Nevertheless I speak concerning Christ" and His standing with you.

The more you minister to yourself, the more the pendulum swings toward the faith that says it is done. You feel it breaking away from the emotions that say it is not. You feel it swinging over until peace, joy, victory, and celebration in the face of circumstances and the devil become so imminent that it is over. It is over, therefore it is over.

"I am going to speak the Word."

Go on and speak it. Worship will make you believe it.

The weapons of our warfare are mighty through God to the pulling down of strongholds, systems of thought empowered by emotion. Those systems begin to create imaginations that leave truth, leave the way things really exist, and start building sandcastles that do not exist. Yet you will believe them.

Those imaginations and every high thing exalt themselves against the knowledge of God. They displace God's Word and His knowledge with their own until you are defeated.

I do not think so.

So why don't you jump up for a minute with both hands lifted, like you are pulling out of a bay? Reach down on the inside where that nature you fellowship with lives, and pour yourself into each statement of adoration.

Oh, hallelujah. How could I have ever doubted You? Hallelujah. You are not a man that You could lie. You have exalted Your Word above Your name. Heaven and earth will pass away, but Your Word abides forever.

I have what I say. I call myself dead to the world and alive unto You, that I may give You all the glory in every circumstance, every standing, every problem.

Oh, I love to meet the devil's onslaught with my hands up and my heart worshiping. In fact, it is insulting to him. He tries to scare you, and you meet him with an avalanche of worship.

It is done.

You place Christ in that place of grace where His blood gave you standing.

For he that walks down this path will soon understand that fellowship with Me is the drink of water that quenches the thirst men cannot quench, nor can they give it to you.

Therefore walk down this path. Minister to yourself. Pay no attention to the emotions that would come your way. Pay no attention.

He just said there will always be an increase. In fact, the very thing you are building yourself above will seem like it comes alive and fights for a while. Especially give no heed when you are doing the right things and those emotions rise up and get worse. Pay special attention during that time. Nurture yourself and continue to build yourself up.

For you will not get too far down this path before I establish Myself in you in such a way, saith the Lord, that you will never turn back. Even the victory that precedes the victory, which is fellowship with Me, saith the Lord, will be too sweet.

That sounds like some nourishing and cherishing there.

Future victory. Standing in church. Hallelujah, Jesus.

I hear some good stuff. I hope it is for you too. He said He is pulling my stops out. You might as well get in on this. Lift your hands and say, "He is pulling my stops out."

There is a little celebration, like He is moving in and giving you some victories before you see them.

Even those weaknesses in you I can overcome. When the Holy Ghost nurtures your nature, when He takes what you have become and magnifies it, then the love of God is shed abroad in your heart, and this gospel and you are made not ashamed.

Therefore be strong in those things that change things, such as fellowship with Me.

Why spend the day at the gate wondering? Enter in and taste and see.

For many of you, your journey is really just beginning: a journey with both sides of the trail laced with victory.

Hear what the Spirit would say. You will stop along the path, for there are many streams and many wells, and you will drink deep. There will be many celebrations. There will be much victory along the way. For when you release the Holy Spirit to take everything that you are in Me, then all things are possible to this person who believes.

Hallelujah. Hallelujah, Jesus.

It does not matter how loud you worship or how quiet you worship. It does not matter how loud or quiet you pray in tongues. I found out, forget the vocal cords. When I am by myself, He does not have any trouble hearing me. Once in a while I will burst out in a little frenzy of excitement, but for the greater part I just say, "I love You." It is just below the level where my vocal cords oscillate.

It is very effective.

I am building myself up. I am making melody. I am ministering to the nourishing and cherishing positional truth: unearnable, provided, Savior of the body, covering of the church, provider, provider, provider.

He wants your neighbor saved worse than you do. He is provider. He is not testing you at the cost of people going to hell by the thousands because you do not have money. He is provider.

The only reason He cannot give it to us is because there are things in us that will not let Him. But you are not going to stay stingy and mean while letting the Holy Ghost minister to your new nature. You may go in mean, but you will come out clean.

That is why the fight of faith is fought by not stopping.

In the middle of the circumstances, hallelujah. If I am not doing everything right, I will be magnified above it, because it cannot stay wrong and have God keep getting bigger in me.

Glory. Glory. Glory. I will repeat myself: glory.

I think I will drop names from high places a little bit.

Jesus. Holy Spirit. Holy Ghost.

The devil has put just about every kind of pressure system against me. You can see he has barred every door. He has parked trains against them. He has done about everything he can do, and it irritates him so badly when I have a party right in the middle of it.

"What are you doing?"

"I am having a party. I am magnifying and glorifying Jesus for positioning me in the place where the Father has made me free."

The devil is not going to hear anything else from me, and I am not going to hear anything else from him. He can park a train against every door into everywhere I am supposed to go. It does not make any difference to me.

My spirit is out of his jurisdiction.

He may park trains against my flesh from every side, but he cannot get in there.

Why do you think, under the shadow, there was an outer court, inner court, and Holy of Holies?

Does the devil know what I am saying when I pray in tongues? No, he does not. Why give him an advantage when you do not even know? He does not know either.

A man, and I believe it was his wife, was being rushed to intensive care. He was heading for the hospital confessing the Word: "She will live and not die. She will live and not die."

Every time he made his confession, he was shattered by emotion. It wracked him so badly he could hardly drive. He would hear, "She will die."

He would say, "No, she will live and not die."

This went on for some time as he was heading to the hospital. Then suddenly, through discerning of spirits, his eyes were opened. That is when you can see what is going on in the realm of the spirit around you, both devils and angels. That day, he saw devils.

God opened his eyes, and there was a devil riding beside him, helping him drive. Another devil was sitting on the other side. Every time the man confessed, "She will live and not die," one devil screamed through his ear to the other one, "She will die."

God told him, "Now make your confession and couple it with praying in tongues."

So he said, "She will live and not die," and began praying in tongues.

God opened his eyes. The devil leaned around the back of his head, looked at the other one, and said, "What do you reckon he is saying?"

The other said, "I do not know, but are you feeling that burning the way I am feeling?"

"Yes, I feel it too."

"Do you reckon we ought to leave?"

"Yes."

Of course he did not understand what the man was praying.

Under the shadow there was the outer court, inner court, and Holy of Holies. Now this is His temple. The Holy of Holies is my born-again human spirit. My inner court is my soul. The outer court is the flesh.

Only one person was allowed into the Holy of Holies, and that was the high priest with the sacrificial offering once a year. If it was not accepted, he died. They had bells on the priest so they could listen for the jingling. If the jingling stopped, they had a hook and would pull him out, because nobody was going in after him.

My Holy of Holies is out of Satan's jurisdiction. Nobody is allowed in there but my High Priest. If the devil ever had the audacity to penetrate the veil of the Holy of Holies, God would take his head off at the shoulders.

So park your trains. Just give my spirit man room to lift his arms, and I will get out of it.

Hallelujah. Give it your best shot.

I worship You. I position Jesus. I take everything in me and magnify You. I position Him in that place where He said I am free.

The devil will hear nothing from my mouth, and I will hear nothing from his mouth except, "I am free."

Who am I ministering to?

Myself.

Psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, making melody in your heart to the Lord, giving thanks for all things to God and the Father.

Do you love that? God and the Father.

It is wonderful having a Father who is not limited to the boundaries of our natural fathers.

"What makes you think you are going to win?"

"Didn't I tell you? My Father's God too."

Giving thanks to God and the Father. The Father part is important. If I were you, I would approach Him as my Father, because you are His son or daughter.

The Jews knew Him as God. That is how they approached Him. They watched Him part the Red Sea. They went before Him in war. They loved Him, but they did not know Him the way you can. You have His nature.

What changed between you and them? Under the shadow, He rested on their souls and carried out His purposes, pursuits, and plans. Before that, under the dispensation of righteousness accounted by faith, the law was added because of sin.

Would it not stand to reason that the thing that has changed between you and them is your nature?

Now He says to give thanks to God and the Father in the name of the One who positioned you in victory: the Lord Jesus Christ.

Here you are, standing there belligerently worshiping Him hour after hour, glorifying Him to God and the Father in that place you have in Him as your Father. That is where you want to approach Him: "Oh, Father."

If this is the part of you that has changed, would it not stand to reason that the victory comes by ministering to that part of you?

Romans 5 talks about being justified by faith and having access by faith into this grace wherein we stand. Paul says we glory, but not only in His glory. We glory also in tribulations.

If we glory in the midst of tribulation, even when trains are parked on every side, that tribulation goes out and employs patience. There is a tribulation that, if you do not do the right thing at the beginning of it, will not employ the God kind of patience. You could have it all your life and terminate from it.

But if you do the right thing when tribulation comes, which is to position Christ, then tribulation goes out and employs patience. Patience goes out and employs experience. Experience keeps multiplying itself in truth, and it needs a vessel to fill up, so it employs hope that receives the substance of faith.

Then hope reaches such a capacity that the Holy Ghost sheds His love abroad in you, the love that makes not ashamed, as you and God blow every train off your door and walk out of there in victory.

All because the emotional realm could not shut you down. All because the devil's cheap shots of parking trains and screaming through the door about what a poor little believer you are could not make you stop positioning Christ in the place that says, "There is your fight."